

21 December 2025

Col Cory Cooper, USAF
Permanent Professor and Head
Department of Mechanical Engineering
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Lt Col Jordan Firth, USSF
Department of Astronautics
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Col Cooper,

Thank you for considering my application to be USAFA's next Permanent Professor and Head of the Department of Astronautics. This position lies directly at the intersection of my passions for education, space, and officer development. The officer selected for this position will be responsible for guiding the continued development of a mutually beneficial relationship between USAFA and Space Force as space becomes increasingly important to America's national security. I believe my career has uniquely prepared me for the leadership USAFA needs to meet this challenge and maintain the institution's strong heritage of world-leading space education and officer preparation.

I am deeply committed to USAFA's mandate to take America's best and brightest young adults and develop leaders of character for the Air Force and Space Force. I have seen first-hand how important this mission is for the military and the nation, and I am proud to support it. I am also passionate about building teams that can accomplish more than any individual. At USAFA this includes recruiting and developing department faculty, empowering them to lead by example and teach officership in addition to engineering.

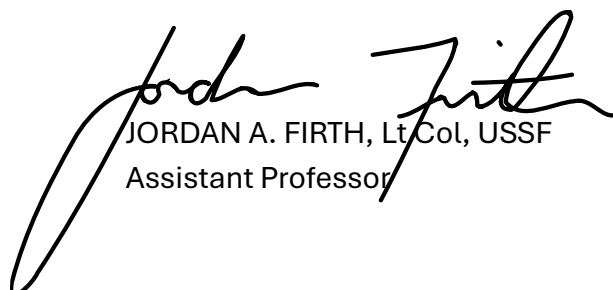
The Air Force and Space Force have provided me with skills, education, and experience that I believe will be invaluable for USAFA and the Department of Astronautics.

- I have five years of teaching experience at USAFA, including courses in two engineering departments. In addition to classroom instruction, course direction, and curriculum development, I have also led the Astro Department's new faculty training program.
- I have three ABET-accredited engineering degrees. My doctoral research consisted of development and zero-g flight test of spacecraft components funded by a NASA grant.
- I led USAFA's ongoing ABET-accreditation work for the Department of Astronautics. I also led the Engineering Division's 2024 Engineering Program Advisory Council (EPAC), a biennial external review ensuring that our engineering programs produce officers ready to meet the technical needs of the Air Force and Space Force.

- In response to a weakness identified by EPAC reviewers, I developed an experimental multi-department course combining technical skills and domain communication. This course is on track for inclusion in USAFA's Course of Instruction as Engr 201 in Fall 2026, and will be a requirement for two engineering majors.
- I have a record of academic research, including peer-reviewed journal articles and support of cadet research leading to student conference presentations.
- I have a record of demonstrated leadership excellence.
 - I served as Acting Squadron Commander for 5 months in USAFA Cadet Group 4. I led two Cadet Squadrons while their Commanders were on extended leave. This included maintaining good order and discipline, commissioning education, and successful preparation for USAFA's inaugural CULEX. In this role I served as a bridge between CW and DF, and directly contributed to cadet success, including AFCWI development. I also worked with USAFA's A1 and Space Detachment to determine USAFA's policy for selecting graduates for commissioning into Space Force.
 - I led a team of 29 intel analysts performing acquisition intelligence at the Defense Intelligence Agency. In this role I reversed a years-long cultural decline and restored trust between military members and DIA civilians in my 150-person office, and led two of my team leads to Directorate/Agency-level FGO-of-the-year awards.
- I also supported commissioning education at NC State's AFROTC Det 595 as a PhD student. When the Detachment Commander was relieved of duty, I coordinated coverage for three instructor positions and personally taught sophomore-level AS 222: Team and Leadership Fundamentals to 27 cadets, preparing them for success at field training directly after course completion.

USAFA established the nation's first undergraduate degree in Astronautical Engineering and maintains an absolute commitment to preparing every graduate with an astronautics background. This commitment has prepared countless officers for leadership in space, even those who unexpectedly ended up in national security space—including me.

I look forward to the responsibility of guiding USAFA and the Department of Astronautics through the ongoing rapid growth of Space Force and the space domain. I believe I have the skills, experience, and passion to succeed as USAFA's next Permanent Professor of Astronautics, and I look forward to the opportunity to discuss the position with you further.



JORDAN A. FIRTH, Lt Col, USSF
Assistant Professor